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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 4 Wamutira: The First Wife

I remember one dance organized by boys for their girls in the area. We would spend the whole night there dancing and then go home the following morning. Those who were a bit brave would walk home during the night. When I was a *mũirĩtu*, I used to laugh a lot and sleep out in the cold night without even a blanket after dancing. As I had nothing to think or worry about, it was the happiest time I can remember. After dancing, I would go home and meet food already cooked and would just start eating. But now the mind is occupied with where to get food, what needs to be done next—like cultivating the tea or coffee, getting food for the cows.

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In those times, the man who was very attractive—who was *kiumbi*—had his own unmarried man's house, which was just one room. Girls, during dances, used to go there every night. We washed ourselves, beautified ourselves, and went to this man's house and spent the night and would not return home until morning. Our oldest mother taught us how to dress ourselves when going there to prevent anything from going wrong. This was by tying ourselves with ropes so that the skirt was tight around the body. This is how we did it—I will show you. [She demonstrates.] Take one edge of the skirt in front, gather it into a knot and tie the rope around it. Then put that knot in between the legs toward the back. Now take the end of the rope and wrap it around each thigh so that when we are fondled by the man he cannot do anything [have sexual intercourse].

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A man who is *kiumbi* is the best dancer, one who is handsome and able to lead songs. The voice, itself, was enough to make one leave a pot cooking over the fire and go and dance! We would spend the night there in this big bed being turned over and over by him all night. So in the morning we would go tell others of our agemates who had not come with us and then they would go that evening to be turned over. With agemates, you can joke about things like that—where you spent the night and who was there. But with those of other *mariika*, you had nothing to talk about.

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We used to go dance just near our home, and one day afterwards Mũrage [her husband] made beer for us at his home. He never invite dme but invited my friend, Kanyiba, and she took me with her. When we went there, Mũrage started talking to me on the subject of love and I told him that I was not interested in him. He realized it, too.

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So, it happened that we had to pay back the beer we were given by having visitors to our place. When Mūrage came, I refused to listen to him, and he thought I was refusing him because of the beer we were taking. One night he came to the granary outside my mother's house and started blowing his nose. When I heard, I started asking, "Who is that?" I 92 vowed not to marry him if it was the same person. I went out and told him to go home because we were going somewhere. He left, but the following night he came again. I went and told him to never com to our house again. But hew started coming near the granary from day to day without stopping. He finished a month doing that.

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